Abstract

Leadership is not solely about setting employees on a path to achieve organizational goals, but also about establishing relationships, building trust, fostering employee engagement, and enabling employees to assume ownership of their work. The aim of this qualitative pilot study was to gain insight into the nature of employee relationship, empowerment, autonomy and work engagement issues that present a challenge to the manager. One manager was interviewed using a semi-structured format and their responses were analysed thematically, with preliminary analysis. Themes that arose from the interview are: trust and open communication, employee empowerment and autonomy, meaningful work and recognition, and adaptive leadership and employee support. The results indicate that the manager believed that good leadership was a relational and developmental process whereby managers give direction and employees have the right to some autonomy. The results were analyzed in the light of literature on leader–member exchange (LMX), psychological empowerment and work engagement. Aggarwal et al. (2020) found that high-quality leader–member exchange was related to psychological empowerment and work engagement. A number of other studies have also found links between empowering leadership and psychological empowerment and work engagement. The results of this pilot, based on a single interview, do not provide generalisation to larger populations, but do yield some initial information on the way the concepts of leadership may be lived out in managerial practice.

Introduction

Leadership is a key element of organizational effectiveness because it affects the way employees perceive their roles, how they work with others and how they can help the organization achieve its goals. In classical management theory, a leader's focus is on planning, organizing, and controlling work, but recent leadership studies have focused on the leader/employee relationship. Managers can also affect employees through informal means such as communicating, trusting, supporting, delegating, and providing employee participation opportunities.

One of the perspectives on leadership that is relevant to these behaviors is leader–member exchange (LMX) theory. LMX centres on the quality of relationships that are formed between individual employees and leaders. Trust, respect, support and exchange of reciprocity in relationships can offer employees more information, resources, responsibility and decision-making opportunities.

Aggarwal et al. (2020) investigated how the leader–member exchange, psychological empowerment, work engagement, and psychological withdrawal behavior are interrelated. They

studied 454 people, all employed in research and development departments in the information technology and pharmaceutical industries in India. The results showed that greater psychological empowerment and work engagement were related to better relationships between leaders and employees. The study also revealed that while psychological empowerment was a mediator between LMX and work engagement, it was not found to be a mediator between MSLX and work engagement.

Researchers have focused on psychological empowerment as a particularly important aspect of leadership due to its focus on the employees' perceptions that their jobs are meaningful, that they can perform their work, that they have autonomy in their work and that they can influence outcomes. Giving employees the needed decision-making authority and opportunities to participate can lead to increased feelings of ownership.

Recent studies have provided further evidence of the connection between empowerment and employee outcomes. Wen et al. (2023) for instance, reported that empowered leadership had a positive correlation with psychological empowerment and work engagement, and psychological empowerment partially mediated the relationship between empowered leadership and work engagement. Likewise, Hashemi et al. (2025) reported positive relationships between leader empowering behavior, psychological empowerment and work engagement among nurses.

In quantitative research, evidence of relationships among these variables is found, but qualitative interviewing can offer a different perspective by examining the managers' own description of the relationships between these variables in terms of how they describe the leadership practices that are a part of these relationships. Hence, this pilot study is based on the experiences of one manager and his perception.

Purpose of the Study

The aim of this pilot qualitative study was to gain better understanding of leadership styles when it comes to employee relationship, empowerment, autonomy and work engagement. One semi-structured interview was employed to gain a preliminary understanding of the managerial leadership practices and to practise the qualitative interview and thematic analysis methods.

Research Question

The following question was the guide to the study:

What are the leadership behaviors that managers employ to build relationships with employees, empower employees and engage employees?

The aim of this study was not to generalise the findings to managers or organisations in general, instead this study was a pilot exercise based on one interview. Rather, themes were to be identified and the experiences of one manager compared to existing leadership research.

Literature Review

Leader–Member Exchange

The theory of leader–member exchange emphasizes the interpersonal dynamics between leaders and members of a group. Instead of the managers' relationship with each of their employees being the same, LMX takes the view that relationships evolve over time through repeated contacts.

Trust, respect, communication, support and mutual obligations are all components of high-quality leader–member relationships. The relationships can offer employees a better opportunity to be involved in decision making and responsibilities.

Aggarwal et al. (2020) discovered that workers who felt good relationships with their leaders were more likely to feel psychologically empowered and engaged at work. Their research offers, therefore, a helpful conceptual context in which to explore the potential for managerial relationships to impact employees' experiences.

The concept is applied qualitatively in this present study, by looking at the descriptions a manager gives for trust, communication, support and relationship with employees.

Psychological Empowerment

Psychological empowerment concerns employees' perceptions of meaning, competence, self-determination, and impact. Empowered employees are more likely to perceive that their work has value, that they possess the capability to perform their responsibilities, that they have some control over how their work is performed, and that their actions can influence organizational outcomes.

Managerial practices can contribute to these perceptions by providing employees with responsibility and opportunities for decision-making. Empowerment does not necessarily mean that managers eliminate supervision. Instead, effective empowerment may involve clearly communicating expectations while allowing employees flexibility in determining how those expectations are achieved.

Aggarwal et al. (2020) found that LMX was positively related to psychological empowerment and that psychological empowerment was positively associated with work engagement.Wen et al. (2023) similarly found that empowering leadership was positively related to both psychological empowerment and work engagement. Their

findings further indicated that psychological empowerment partially mediated the relationship between empowering leadership and engagement.

These findings suggest that leadership practices that increase employees' sense of autonomy and influence may be important mechanisms through which managers support engagement.

Work Engagement

Employees' active involvement and psychological investment in their jobs are referred to as 'work engagement'.Engaged employees tend to show energy, dedication, and an involvement in their responsibilities.

Leadership impacts engagement as they shape employee's experience at the workplace. For example, engaging employees through giving them meaningful responsibilities, providing support from their manager, helping employees understand the contribution of their job towards bigger objectives, and creating opportunities for employees to practice appropriate autonomy.According to Aggarwal et al., 2020, there existed positive association between work engagement and LMX as well as psychological empowerment.

Furthermore, more recently, Hashemi et al. (2025) have identified a number of significant positive relationships between leader empowering behaviours, psychological empowerment, and work engagement. In their analysis they identify psychological empowerment as mediating the relationship between empowering leadership and engagement. These studies therefore provided an initial basis to consider whether there are similarly conceptually related findings emerging within the experiences articulated by our interviewee manager for this pilot study.

Methodology

Research Design

A qualitative pilot design was used for this study. Because the purpose was to gain understanding of the participant's experiences and perceptions, rather than to statistically test the relationships among variables, qualitative research was indicated.

The main method of data collection was a semi-structured interview. Questions were pre-designed in an open-ended format and were followed by probing questions if necessary

to better understand the concept.I was allowed to do one interview in the assignment as it was an introduction to the process of interviewing and initial analysis.

Participant

The participant was a supervisor and manager with knowledge and experience in leading and managing workers. The participant will be referred to in this report as Manager Participant to protect the identity of the participant.The participant was chosen for his managerial experience, which would provide the context for talking about employee relationships, delegation, decision making, employee engagement and challenges in leadership.The following confidentiality of organizational information, proprietary information, customer information, and personally identifiable information of other employees was not requested:

Informed Consent

The participant was given and read an informed consent form prior to the interview. Informed consent was achieved by signing a consent form with the participant in person prior to the start of the interview.

The form of consent stated the purpose of the educational pilot study, responsibilities of the participants, voluntary participation, possible risks and benefits, how the data will be kept confidential, how the data will be protected, and contact information.

The participant was told that the participation was voluntary and that he/she could refrain from answering any question. The participant was also told that the interview was for educational purposes only and that identifying information would not be included in the report to the written interview.

Please remember that the signed informed consent form is in Appendix B.

Interview Procedure

The interview was held in person and took about 30-45 minutes.

A series of eight open-ended questions were explored to explore participant's approach to:

- manager–employee relationships;
- trust and communication;
- employee empowerment;
- decision-making authority;
- autonomy;
- meaningful work;

- employee engagement; and
- leadership challenges.

Follow up prompts were used when additional explanation was warranted.The participant gave permission to the researcher to use comprehensive notes during the interview.

Data Analysis

Preliminary thematic analysis was used to analyze the responses from the interviews.
The researcher first examined the interview transcript to get acquainted with the interviewee's answers. Second, the statements pertinent to the research question were located. Thirdly, codes for concepts that appeared more than once were given to the initial concepts. Fourth, codes were aggregated in a larger level of grouping. Lastly, categories were compared to see if there was a meaningful pattern related to the interview as a whole. During the initial coding process, ideas emerged such as:

- trust;
- communication;
- managerial support;
- delegation;
- employee autonomy;
- decision-making;
- recognition;
- meaningful work;
- employee engagement;
- adaptability;
- accountability; and
- leadership development.

Similarities in these codes were explored and in conjunction with the research question and the key literature on leadership, the final themes were generated.

Findings

Theme 1: Trust and Open Communication

Trust and open communication were highlighted by both managers as being a key to effective leadership. The manager stated:

“Trust has always been a fundamental component of effective leadership for me because I want my employees to feel comfortable enough to approach me about their issues or if they have suggestions regarding how we can improve our work processes.”

To ensure ongoing communication between herself and her employees, she also talked about the importance of having regular one-on-one conversations with them.The participant stated:

“I try to develop these [relationships] based upon mutual trust, respect & open communication.” “We also have a tendency to talk too much,” he continued. “What I mean by that is we’re less likely to tell you things, if you’re always trying to give us feedback on your performance.”

From what emerged from this exchange, the manager sees communication as an interaction between parties (two-way) rather than merely a tool to convey information. In particular, the idea that listening precedes speaking suggests the value he places on maintaining relationships with his staff through consistent communication and accessibility.These findings are consistent with what Aggarwal et al. (2020) discussed about LMX theory where there exists an association between the quality of relationships between leaders and their employees to employee’s psychological experiences and engagement.

Theme 2: Employee Empowerment and Autonomy

Empowerment and Autonomy Theme – “Intentionally give those that have experience on our team more opportunity for taking ownership over certain things and making decisions.” For instance, this manager mentioned allowing one employee to take ownership of a specific reporting process she has developed significant expertise about (and which he would have continued to control), but adding he’d also maintain appropriate oversight.The participant explained:

However, it was more about providing them with an opportunity for decision making that is within certain boundaries,” said the manager. “I am just trying to strike a balance there”.Further, when asked to explain what he considered to be the most important elements of leadership, the manager indicated:

“Employees need to know their deadlines and things they are required to deliver on – so they know their responsibilities. But they are left free to determine how best to achieve those outcomes”.

Psychological empowerment refers to ‘the process by which individuals come to view themselves as having control over their work context’ (Saks et al., 2013), which

can be seen in this participant's approach to managing his team. By enabling employees to have opportunities to make decisions, yet ensuring managerial accountability, this participant appears to reflect a high degree of psychological empowerment.For instance, Aggarwal et al.'s study (Aggarwal et al., 2020) also identified that LMX was positively related to psychological empowerment as well. Similarly, empowering leadership was positively associated with psychological empowerment and work engagement according to Wen et al.'s findings (Wen et al., 2023).

On the basis of this evidence, the manager's answers shed light on how empowerment can manifest itself in terms of delegation, autonomy, and opportunities for making decisions.

Theme 3: Meaningful Work and Recognition

This is where "meaningful work and recognition" comes in. Sometimes we get too bogged down in doing things and don't understand the big picture of what our organization aims to achieve. As much as I can, I try and let them know why certain things are done – and who will use that piece of information/work product. The manager says.

The participant stated:

I also want them to connect [individual] responsibilities with our bigger picture for the team," he said. "Recognition doesn't mean you have to give out big formal recognitions… Just acknowledging your contribution is valuable communication – it says we notice and value what you do." This speaks to psychological empowerment dimensions of meaning and impact. Knowing your work has significance and affects others can create a greater sense of purpose.

In addition, this research finding is related to work engagement since there exists a positive correlation between psychological empowerment and work engagement (Aggarwal et al., 2020). Manager's response indicates that creation of meaning and recognition of contributions are considered to be good approaches towards enhancing employees' involvement at work.

Theme 4: Adaptive Leadership and Employee Support

"Employees have different personalities, experience level, needs and motivation; thus I do not apply the exact same leadership approach to all employees," said this manager

The participant explained:"Leadership is not one-size-fits-all."

For those that are new to their role, the manager provided more direction and increased autonomy for those with more experience and demonstrated competencies.

“When an employee seemed less engaged, I sought to understand the situation before concluding there was a motivational issue… I tried to understand what was going on underneath by asking them things like how much they had to do, what were they resourcing, what were their expectations?” asked the manager.

Adaptive element of leader’s leadership approach. Theme 5 illustrates the adaptive nature of this particular leaders’ leadership approach. They adjust the degree of direction/supervision based upon the specific circumstance experienced by the employee. This finding can be linked to the relationship-based nature of LMX. Instead of focusing on leadership as being one standardized behaviour, this participant placed more emphasis on knowing each individual employee and having that knowledge shape their own approach to forming the relationship.

Discussion

These results indicate a strong connection between effective leadership and factors such as trust, communication, employee empowerment, and adaptability. As previously mentioned, the manager stressed establishing positive relationships, promoting open communication, and granting employees autonomy while holding them accountable.

Findings from studies conducted by Aggarwal et al., (2020) and Wen et al., (2023) indicate that fostering positive leader-member relationships may also promote psychological empowerment and increase work engagement. According to Hashemi et al.’s (2025) study, empowering leadership has been positively correlated with enhanced levels of psychological empowerment among employees.

In conclusion, these interview findings highlight the importance of creating trusting relationships, assigning meaningful responsibilities to employees, and adjusting your leadership style based on individual requirements. This case report provides insightful guidance regarding best-practices and considerations when seeking to engage employees through leadership initiatives despite having only performed one interview during this analysis.

Implications for Leadership Practice

A few preliminary points could be inferred from these results.

Firstly, there are certain aspects of leading that managers might want to focus on consistently. For instance, managers could engage themselves into having consistent communications with their employees about how to build trust effectively. Such regular discussions will give employees an opportunity to address issues proactively without creating complications.

Secondly, it could be interesting to see how managers have been able to delegate certain tasks to employees which require them to work independently but still maintain accountability over the outcome. Managers can use this opportunity to provide their employee team with adequate autonomy while ensuring that they gain required level of competency to perform effectively.

Recognizing how individuals contribute helps managers to reinforce the significance of what employees do, linking individual efforts to overarching goals for the wider team or organization.

Ultimately, it's important for managers to adapt their leadership style according to specific employee circumstances. For example, there will often be variations in required support based on employee experience. Likewise, a fall-off in engagement might need more detailed analysis than other issues if effective responses are to be identified.

Limitations

Limitation 1 – One Manager Only. It would have been ideal for this research to include more than just one participant however due to the nature of this being a pilot study it was permissible for this research to focus solely on the one participant. However with that limitation comes the understanding that these findings cannot be generalised to all managers or organisations.

Limitation 2 – Self Report. These findings also depend on the perception of the one individual (manager) who provided them. There can be no doubt that employees will see their manager's leadership practice quite differently to how he/she saw himself/herself. In fact an interesting follow-up piece of research might look at incorporating the employee interviews into such studies.

Thirdly, my interpretation could influence the way that I identify and organize the themes.Lastly, due to limitations placed upon me by time constraints, the study does not investigate the subject's leadership behaviors over an extended period (longitudinal). Future work could investigate if the subject's leadership remains constant regardless of organisational setting.

It must also be noted how diverse the range of studies are with which we conduct our own Literature Review. Agarwal et al (2020) studied "the perceptions of 454 employees working in IT and pharmaceutical R&D sectors in India" – a vastly different study from those found here in this report who focus on just one managers' perspectives. Thus when comparing interview results to those already published there can only ever be conceptual links made.

Conclusion

A qualitative pilot study was conducted to explore how the manager approached leadership challenges involving employee relationships, empowerment, autonomy, and engagement. The interviews produced four themes regarding trust and open communication; employee empowerment and autonomy; meaningful work and recognition; and adaptive leadership and employee support. The manager's responses suggested their leadership approach involved fostering developing trusting relationships and granting appropriate degrees of autonomy to employees while also establishing connections between the nature of their employees' jobs and the goals and objectives of the organization as a whole while providing flexibility for different types of managerial support depending upon specific employee needs. The results are conceptually consistent with prior research such as Aggarwal et al.'s (2020) identification of relationships between leader-member exchange, psychological empowerment, and work engagement; Wen et al.'s (2023) finding that empowering leadership was linked with both psychological empowerment and work engagement; and the further insights offered by Hashemi et al.'s (2025).

As discussed earlier, these results cannot be generalized due to this single participant design. However, this pilot study has illustrated the potential that qualitative interviews have for providing insights into how leadership concepts manifest themselves within the experiences of managers.

Future studies should include multiple managers as well as employees who work with them so they may be able to compare what the leaders report about their practice versus employee's perception.

References

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Appendix A

Interview Topic: Leadership Practices, Employee Empowerment, and Work Engagement

1. Describe the types of working relationships that you try to develop with members of your team. What do you do to build trust and foster open communication between you and your employees?
2. Describe a time when you had given one of your employees more responsibility/authority to make decisions. What influenced your actions?
3. How would you describe your approach to balancing giving people direction vs. creating space for them to operate independently?

Leadership Practices:

1. What strategies do you use to create the perception (or reality) among your employees that what they are doing is important and impacts your team/organization?
2. Recognizing Engagement Issues: How do you know if someone is becoming disengaged/disconnected from their job? How do you address this?
3. Describe a leadership challenge where the nature of your relationship with an employee impacted the way that you handled or resolved this.
4. What has been learned from reflecting on your own leadership experiences as far as building effective relationships with employees and keeping them engaged?

Follow-Up Prompts

- Could you tell me more about your experience?
- What motivated you to choose this strategy? How did the employee respond?
- The outcome of the situation.
- Would you have handled this situation any differently today?
- Did you see any changes in how I approached my leadership after that event?
- So what have we learned from our experience?

Appendix B

Letter of Informed Consent

Leadership Practices, Employee Empowerment, and Work Engagement: A Qualitative Pilot Interview

This research activity has been carried out by Rishika Thakur who is currently studying as a doctoral student at Westcliff University. The current research is also an assignment requirement for the Doctor of Business Administration (DBA) program.

Purpose of the Study

This educational pilot study aims at exploring how a manager approaches leadership challenges concerning employee relationships, empowerment, autonomy and work engagement.This interview provides an opportunity for preliminary qualitative insights into the management's leadership practices. It also enables us to put into practice qualitative interviews as well as thematic analysis.

Participant Criteria

Based on your current or past responsibility for supervising, leading, or managing employees, we'd appreciate the opportunity to hear about your experiences with managing employee relationships and maintaining employee engagement through effective leadership practices.

Participant Tasks and Time Commitment

We asked a person to participate in an interview as part of our study (i.e., we offered them informed consent for participation). We explained that interview would last about 30-45 min, and included open-ended questions regarding their experiences with leadership, their relationship(s) with employees, how they empowered their employees, engaged them, communicated with them, and their experiences of challenges associated with their leadership roles.Participant is free to decline to answer any question that arises. Finally, we requested that participant give us permission to record interviews by audio to aid our accurate analysis. If they did not want to be recorded, we would keep written notes only.

Participant Rights

Your participation in this study is entirely voluntary. You are free to refuse to answer any of our questions during the interview or to withdraw from participation in the study at any time without experiencing any consequences or penalties for doing so.Your decision to either participate or not to participate does not impact on your employment, academic status, or relationship with us as researchers

Risks

There are no anticipated risks other than what might occur by participating in a typical professional interview (e.g., some questions could prompt reflection of your experiences on the job or as a leader). Please do not answer a question if you feel it is making you uncomfortable. Please also understand that this is an interview where I will be asking for specific types of information – including things such as confidential business information, proprietary information, customer information, employee personal information or other sensitive organizational information. So please remember to not share any of this information unless explicitly asked about it.

Benefits

There are no potential direct personal benefits for participants. There may be some indirect benefit through reflection of your own leadership experiences and managerial practices.Further there may be an educational benefit as I have an opportunity to refine my skill sets around conducting qualitative interviews and carrying out preliminary thematic analyses.

Compensation or Incentives

You will receive no compensation or financial incentive for participating in this study.

Data Collection and Protection

I will collect all necessary information based on your responses to my questions and, with your consent, by audio-recording our conversation. I may take written notes either during the interview or immediately afterward. Your full name and other identifying information are not to appear in this report. I'll refer to you simply as "Manager Participant," or, when that's not possible, as "Participant 1." Finally, please understand that what we talk about today will only be used for educational purposes as part of my coursework assignment. If you're okay with me including direct quotes from us in this report, please indicate that now.

Do not disclose any confidential organizational information, proprietary information, customer information, employee personal information or other sensitive information about you during this interview.

Data Security

All research material such as the signed consent form, the interview notes, audio recordings etc., will be secured and considered as confidential.The electronic research materials are going to be secured by placing them into a password protected location that can only be accessed by the researcher while physical documents will be kept safe in a secured location. Research record & data will be preserved and handled accordingly to westcliff university requirement.

Contact Information

If you have questions about this study or concerns about your participation, you may contact:

Researcher: Rishika Thakur
Email: r.thakur.5878@westcliff.edu

For questions regarding participants' rights, you may contact:

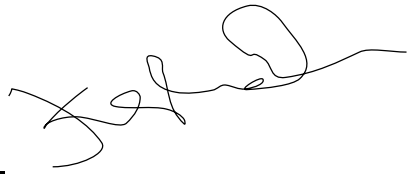
Westcliff University Institutional Review Board
Email: IRB@westcliff.edu

Voluntary Informed Consent Acknowledgement

My signature below certifies that I have read and understand the explanation of this research study and what is being asked of me as a participant. I also understand that my participation in this study is completely voluntary and I am able to withdraw my consent at any time, for any reason, without penalty.

By signing this document, I consent to participate in the study and acknowledge that I know who to contact if I have questions or concerns about my participation. I have been given a copy of this consent form.

Name of Participant (printed): Karan Shah

Signature of Participant: __ 

Date: 09/18/2026

Name of Principal Investigator/Researcher (printed): Rishika Thakur

Signature of Principal Investigator/Researcher: _ 

Date: 09/18/2026